the pandemic hit the state in early 2021). In July 2020, in the week I travelled to Mathura, the party's city unit had conducted Zoom meetings between Deputy Chief Minister Dinesh Maurya and local groups of beneficiaries: those with BPL cards who had recently got electricity connections, those who had received chulhas under a government scheme and so on. Such meetings, local officials told me, had been conducted 'scheme by scheme'.

How did they manage this, I asked. A district-level party official explained: 'All [government] departments today have lists. We do aadaan-pradaan [exchange] of those lists. The lists also have phone numbers. Without a phone number, nobody becomes a labharthee. So, for example, PM Awaas Yojana has houses, those lists come to us. We check them from our side. We see if it is correct or not, whether there are complaints or not, if there is a problem or not … We had full names. That is how we can now approach them and call them for Zoom calls. Then only we can connect them with the Zoom app.'[49]

Data was key to this entire outreach. 'Our work in the lockdown has not stopped,' said the district leader. 'But it has all gone online.' What did this mean for their daily work as party workers at the district, I asked. 'One mahamantri has a permanent duty on the computer for this only,' he responded with a wry smile. 'For this work with data and database.'[50]

WhatsApp Groups, Social Listening, Outreach and IT Heads

There has been a lot of attention on the use of WhatsApp in India for spreading fake news (see Chapter 7). But the BJP's use of it as a fundamental tool of party organisation has been relatively underappreciated. Alongside its leadership structure at the district levels, the party instituted a parallel governance structure for IT after 2014. These new IT teams mirrored the BJP's organisational structure at every administrative level, working in coordination with it. For instance, the party leadership has divided UP into six regions. An IT head was appointed for each of these. So, if we take Braj region (one of the six), the IT head had a second tier of IT heads for each district that came under his jurisdiction. Within districts, each